

MERT KOBAS

New York University, Department of Psychology
6 Washington Place New York, NY 10003
mertkobas@nyu.edu

EDUCATION

New York University, New York, United States Ph.D. in Cognition & Perception, GPA: 3.89/4.00	09.2021 – 05.2026
Koç University, İstanbul, Turkey M.A. in Developmental Psychology GPA: 3.89/4.00	09.2018 – 08.2021
Boğaziçi University, İstanbul, Turkey B.A in Guidance and Psychological Counseling under Educational Sciences Graduated with honors GPA: 3.43/4.00	09.2012 – 07.2018
Radboud University, Nijmegen, The Netherlands Student in Psychology Department, Erasmus Plus Program	08.2016 – 01.2017

PUBLICATIONS

Peer Reviewed Articles

- Kobaş, M.**, Demir-Lira, Ö., Akman, İ., & Göksun, T. (2025). Spatial Language Development in Preterm and Full-Term Infants: The Role of Object Exploration and Parents' Spatial Input. *Journal of Experimental Child Psychology*, 256, 106264.
- Horne, Z., **Kobaş, M.**, & Cimpian, A. (2025). Historical and experimental evidence that inherent properties are overweighted in early scientific explanation. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 122 (38), e2424725122.
- Doğan, I., Kızıldere, E., **Kobaş, M.**, Aktan-Erciyes, A., Demir-Lira, Ö. E., Akman, İ., & Göksun, T. (2025). Early parental multimodal input is differentially associated with later vocabulary knowledge for preterm and full-term infants. *Language Learning and Development*, 1-27.
- Kobaş, M.**, Kızıldere, E., Doğan, I., Aktan-Erciyes, A., Demir-Lira, Ö., Akman, İ., & Göksun, T. (2023). Motor skills, language development, and visual processing in preterm and full-term infants. *Current Psychology*, 1-13.
- Turan, E., **Kobaş, M.**, & Göksun, T. (2021). Spatial Language and Mental Transformation in Preschoolers: Does Relational Reasoning Matter? *Cognitive Development*, 57, 100980.
- Kobaş, M.**, Aktan-Erciyes, A., & Göksun, T. (2021). Fine Motor Abilities and Parental Input of Spatial Features Predict Object Word Comprehension of Turkish-Learning Children. *Infant and Child Development*, 30(4), e2243.

Schoenegger, P., Salvi, F., Liu, J., Nan, X., Debnath, R., Fasolo, B., Leivada, E., Recchia, G., Günther, F., Zarifhonarvar, A., Kwon, J., Islam, Z. U., Dehnert, M., Lee, D. Y. H., Reinecke, M. G., Kamper, D. G., **Kobaş, M.**, Sandford, A., Kgomo, J., ... Karger, E. (under review). Large Language Models Are More Persuasive Than Incentivized Human Persuaders.

Peer Reviewed Conference Proceedings

Ateş, T., Ateşoğlu, Ş., Yiğit, Ç., Kesen, İ., **Kobaş, M.**, Erdem, E., Erdem, A., Göksun, T., & Yüret, D. (2022). CRAFT: A Benchmark for Causal Reasoning About Forces and interactions. 60th Annual Meeting of the Association for Computational Linguistics.

Ateş, T., Ateşoğlu, Ş., Yiğit, Ç., Kesen, İ., **Kobaş, M.**, Erdem, E., Erdem, A., Göksun, T., & Yüret, D. (2020). CRAFT: A Benchmark for Causal Reasoning About Forces and interactions. NeurIPS Shared Visual Representations in Human & Machine Intelligence Workshop.

Manuscripts under preparation

Kobaş, M., & Cimpian, A. (in preparation). Reconciling two competing views on the process of generating explanations: Rational inference vs. intuitive biases.

Liu, J., Lee, D. Y. H., **Kobaş, M.**, Debnath, R., Tao, M., Kamper, D. G., Nan, X., Islam, Z. U., Dehnert, M., Reinecke, M. G., Sandford, A., Salatiello, A., ... Zeng, Q. (in preparation). Big Questions in Artificial Intelligence Across Social Sciences: Interdisciplinary Perspectives of Human-AI Interaction Research Priorities.

Kobaş, M., Yılmaz, B., & Göksun, T. (in preparation). The relationship between vocabulary and executive function skills in preterm and full-term toddlers.

Duan, O., **Kobaş, M.**, & Cimpian, A. (in preparation). Revisiting the Psychometric Characteristics of the Developmental Cognitive Reflection Test.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

Kobaş, M., & Cimpian, A. (2026, April). Reconciling two competing views on the process of generating explanations: Rational inference vs. intuitive biases. Oral presentation was accepted to be presented at the Cognitive Development Society (CDS) 2026 Biennial Conference, Montreal, Canada.

Kobaş, M., & Cimpian, A. (2025, May). Reconciling two competing views on the process of generating explanations: Rational inference vs. intuitive biases. Poster presented at the Society for Research in Child Development (SRCD) 2025 Biennial Meeting, Minneapolis, MN.

Kobaş, M., Horne, Z., & Cimpian, A. (2023, July). The Inherence Bias in Scientific Explanations. Poster presented at 1st Minds, Brains, and Machine Summer Poster Conference, New York, NY.

- Kobaş, M.**, Tworek, C. M., & Cimpian, A. (2023, July). Expertise mitigates the inference bias in everyday explanations. Poster presented at 45th Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society, CogSci 2023, Sydney, Australia.
- Kobaş, M.**, Aktan-Erciyes, A., & Göksun, T. (2021, July). Fine Motor Abilities and Parental Input of Object Dimensions Predict Receptive Language. Poster presented at the 15th International Association for the Study of Child Language, Philadelphia, PA.
- Kobaş, M.**, Kızıldere, E., Aktan-Erciyes, A., Doğan, I., & Göksun, T. (2021, July). Fine Motor Abilities, Visual Perception, and Language Development in Preterm and Term Infants. Poster presented at the 15th International Association for the Study of Child Language, Philadelphia, PA.
- Kızıldere, E., **Kobaş, M.**, Doğan, I., Aktan-Erciyes, A., Demir-Lira, E., & Göksun, T. (2021, July). Event Representation, Parental Spatial Input, and Relational Language Comprehension in Full-Term and Preterm Infants. Paper Presented in Demir-Lira (chair), Beyond Quantity-Quality: Specifying Aspects of High-Quality Parental Language Input that Predict Optimal Child Outcomes. International Congress for the Study of Child Language, Philadelphia, PA.
- Doğan, I., **Kobaş, M.**, Kızıldere, E., Aktan-Erciyes, A., Demir-Lira, E., & Göksun, T. (2021, July). Parental Verbal Input in Different Gestational Weeks and Atypical Development. Poster Presented at the International Congress for the Study of Child Language, Philadelphia, PA.
- Turan, E., **Kobaş, M.**, Aktan-Erciyes, A., & Göksun, T. (2021, July). Turkish children's learning of postpositions: The role of spatial representations. Poster Presented at the International Congress for the Study of Child Language, Philadelphia, PA.
- Kobaş, M.**, & Göksun, T. (2021, June). Early Walking Leads to Changes in Parents' Spatial Input. Poster presented at the Development in Motion Conference (Virtual Conference).
- Kızıldere, E., **Kobaş, M.**, Doğan, I., Aktan-Erciyes, A., Demir-Lira, E., Akman, İ. & Göksun, T. (2021, April). Parents' spatial language scaffolds pre-and full-term infants' mental rotation skills. Poster presented at Society for Research in Child Development (SRCD) Biennial Meeting (Virtual Symposium).
- Doğan, I., **Kobaş, M.**, Kızıldere, E., Aktan-Erciyes, A., Demir-Lira, E., Akman, İ. & Göksun, T. (2021, April). Parents' gestural but not verbal input associates with word comprehension in pre-and full-term infants. Poster presented at Society for Research in Child Development (SRCD) Biennial Meeting (Virtual Symposium).
- Kobaş, M.**, Aktan-Erciyes, A. & Göksun, T. (2021, January). Fine Motor Abilities, Visual Perception and Executive Functions in Preterm and Full-Term Infants. Poster presented at the 11th Budapest CEU Conference on Cognitive Development, Budapest, Hungary.
- Kobaş, M.**, Kızıldere, E., Aktan-Erciyes, A., Doğan, I., & Göksun, T. (2020, January). Gross Motor Abilities, Visual Perception, and Language Development in Preterm and Term Infants. Poster presented at the 10th Budapest CEU Conference on Cognitive Development, Budapest, Hungary.
- Turan, E., **Kobaş, M.**, Altunay, H., Esmer, Ş., Erkekli, E., & Göksun, T. (2020, January). The Effects of Relational Language on Children's Spatial Cognition. Poster presented at the 10th Budapest CEU Conference on Cognitive Development, Budapest, Hungary.

HONORS & AWARDS

NYU GSAS Dean's Travel Grant

Spring 2025 & Fall 2025

- Awarded by the NYU GSAS Dean to support travel and presentation at a scholarly conference

MacCracken Fellowship

2021 - 2026

- Multi-year doctoral fellowship from NYU GSAS providing full tuition, health insurance, and stipend support for Ph.D. studies.

Academic Excellence Award, Koç University

2021

- One-time graduation honor awarded to graduate students for exceptional academic achievement at Koç University, Turkey.

Fee Waivers for BCCCD 2021, 2020, & 2018

2021 & 2020

- 11th and 10th Budapest CEU Conference on Cognitive Development

Boğaziçi University *cum laude*

2018

Ministry of National Education Scholarship

2012–2017

- National award granted by the Ministry of National Education to only 5,000 top students admitted to education programs across Turkey.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

New York University, Cognitive Development Laboratory, New York

Present

Prof. Andrei Cimpian

- Experimental task design, data analysis, participant recruitment, data visualization, and conceptualization of a study investigating the theories about how people generate explanations
- Survey design, participant recruitment, data analysis, data visualization, and conceptualization of a study investigating scientific explanations
- Survey data analysis, and conceptualization of a study investigating the relation between expertise and cognitive biases

Koç University Language and Cognition Laboratory, İstanbul

10.2018 – 08.2021

Prof. Tilbe Göksun

- Data analysis and project management from preschoolers for the study investigating the relationship between spatial abilities and relational language
- Experimental task design, survey design, data analysis, participant recruitment, coding and collection for the study investigating longitudinal relationship between event representation, language development & motor abilities in infants and children
- Experimental task design, survey design, data collection and conceptual support for a machine learning project related to intuitive physics

Educational Sciences at Boğaziçi University, İstanbul
Asst. Prof. Nihal Yeniad

02.2017 – 06.2017

- Contributed to literature search & project organization on attention, well-being and parent-child interaction.

Koç University Independent Evaluation Laboratory, İstanbul
Asst. Prof. Yasemin Kisbu Sakarya

06.2017 – 08.2017

- Chosen under the Koç University Summer Research Program, helped data collection from adults on the brief psychosocial intervention and assisted report for intervention evaluation.

Meta-Analysis Study, Educational Sciences at Boğaziçi University, İstanbul
Asst. Prof. Nihal Yeniad (collaboration with Dr. Michael Sulik from NYU)

05.2016 – 08.2016

- Contributed to literature search on executive functions, depression and well-being.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

- | | |
|---|-------------|
| • Teaching Assistant, Masters Statistics
(PSYCH-GA.2016, Prof. Elizabeth A. Bauer) | Spring 2026 |
| • Teaching Assistant, Masters Statistics
(PSYCH-GA.2016, Prof. Elizabeth A. Bauer) | Fall 2025 |
| • Instructor, Statistics for the Behavioral Sciences
(PSYCH-UA.10) | Summer 2025 |
| • Teaching Assistant, Masters Statistics
(PSYCH-GA.2016, Prof. Elizabeth A. Bauer) | Spring 2025 |
| • Teaching Assistant, Masters Statistics
(PSYCH-GA.2016, Dr. Aspen Yoo) | Fall 2024 |
| • Teaching Assistant, Masters Statistics
(PSYCH-GA.2016, Prof. Elizabeth A. Bauer) | Spring 2024 |
| • Teaching Assistant, Research Methods in Psychology
(Psyc 301; Prof. Tilbe Göksun) | Spring 2020 |
| • Teaching Assistant, Lifespan Development
(Psyc 206; Prof. Tilbe Göksun) | Fall 2019 |
| • Teaching Assistant, Cognitive Development
(Psyc 445; Prof. Tilbe Göksun) | Spring 2019 |
| • Teaching Assistant, Issues in Psychology
(Psyc 210; Prof. Fuat Balcı) | Fall 2018 |

UNDERGRADUATE & GRADUATE MENTORING

Madelyn Zamelis (2025 - present)
Ariella Pevzner (2024 – present)
Stephanie Yandun* (2024 – 2025)
Maya Rabago (2023 – 2025)
Emma Baxendale (2023-2024, M.A. Student)
Olivia Duan** (2023 – present, NYU Dean's Undergraduate Research Fund recipient,
Coons/Leibowitz Award for Honors Research recipient)
Vidisha Goyal *** (2021 – 2022)
Taygun Yorulmaz (2020-2021)
Onur Akın (2019-2020)
Elif Erkekli (2019-2021, Koç University Summer Research Program)
Mahmut Kurupınar (2019-2020, Koç University Summer Research Program)
Gülfem Sarı (2019-2020, Koç University Summer Research Program)

* Student mentee presented research project at the NYU 2nd Annual DreamMakers Summit

** Student mentee presented research project at the NYU Undergraduate Research Conference,

*** Student mentee presented a research project and was awarded best poster at the NYU Undergraduate Research Conference

Professional Service

Conference Reviewing

- NeurIPS 2022 Shared Visual Representations in Human & Machine Intelligence (SVRHM)
- 13th Budapest Central European University Conference on Cognitive Development
- The ACM Symposium on Virtual Reality Software and Technology (VRST) 2025

Co-reviewing

- Infant and Child Development
- Child Development

Moderation

- PsyArXiv

SKILLS

Languages

- Turkish, English, German

Computer

- R, Python, SPSS, JASP, Jamovi
- Elan, Datavyu, Octoparse, Qualtrics, Maxqda
- Microsoft Office, Adobe Illustrator, Adobe Photoshop, Adobe Premier, Logic Pro